

Leeks

CULTIVARS

- King Richard (Summer)
- Tadorna (Fall)

INTENSIVE SPACING

- 3 rows (12"- 30 cm), spaced every 6" (15 cm) on the row

FERTILIZATION

- Leeks will do great in beds that were previously amended with compost and fertilized with a mix of alfalfa meal (2-0-2) and pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2).
- At mid-point of the crop, we top dress with more alfalfa meal (2-0-2) and pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2)

IRRIGATION

Irrigation Type

- Drip tape (4 per bed) or sprinkler, although drip tape may interfere with hilling the leeks

Irrigation Management

- Root depth: Shallow (6"-24")
- General: Never let the soil dry out

IMPLANTATION

Leeks are a reliable, popular and relatively easy crop to grow. Growing them with long white blanch stem is the secret to their popularity and one of the reasons why we bury them at the seedling stage of their growth. The other factor is that with this technique, we don't need to hill them much and can space them more intensively 3 rows over our 30" (75cm) beds.

We plant our summer and fall leeks with different maturity dates at the same time and harvest in succession. They are planted alongside storage onions and parsnips, all crops which spend a major part of the season in the fields (+/- 110 days).

To grow pencil thick transplants, we start our leeks 6 weeks before the transplant date in harvest crates that are at least 3 times as deep as regular seeding trays. We trim their tops and fertilize them twice during their stay in the nursery.

EQUIPMENT

- Broadfork
- Rotary harrow
- 30" bed prep rake
- Leek dibbler
- Scissors

ITINERARY

- Remove tarp and clean out large debris. Use the rake if needed.
- Pass through beds with the broadfork.
- Uniformly apply amendments and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 2" (5 cm). To make transplanting easier (seeing as the soil is loose after being harrowed), we only prepare the beds when we are about to transplant.
- Pass with the leek dibbler to mark the planting holes. If the wholes tend to crumble, water the bed surface first with your irrigation system. The success of the technic lies in making perfect hollow long holes for the leeks to grow into.
- Once the holes are ready, bring out the well-watered trays from the nursery and remove the leek seedlings from them. They'll be planted bare root.
- Using scissors, trim the roots at 1"(2.5cm). To have uniform seedlings, also trim their tops at about 10"(25cm). Leeks less than 8" (20cm) are not planted.
- Drop each leek seedling in a hole, pressing them down at the bottom. In the end, more than 1" (2.5cm) should be sticking out of the ground.

- Install irrigation and water gently until the soil is deeply moistened.

WEEDING

- 10-14 days after transplanting, cultivate gently around the young leeks using a stirrup hoe. The goal here is to destroy small emerging weeds, but most importantly, to bring some soil in the bottom of each leeks hole.
- From there on out, use the bio-disc every 15 days to cultivate on the row and between the rows in one single pass. With each passage, hilling your leeks a little more each time.
- 6 to 7 weeks before harvest, put straw about over the leeks, leaving them as such until the harvest. +/- 5" (13cm) of straw should be enough to help further out the blanching process.

PLANT PROTECTION

- The leek moth is a known pest of alliums, including onion, garlic and green onions, but leeks seem to attract them the most. In most cases, the damages are not sufficient to bother, but on the contrary use insect netting to protect developing plants from damage
- In cool rainy summers, downy mildew and purple blotch (*Alternaria porri*) can be a problem and in such cases, weekly application of copper and sulphate can help diminish the infestations. Application timing is critical, with early action giving best results.

HARVEST

- Leeks are harvested and cleaned in the fields
- First, loosen the soil with a broadfork, then pulls the leeks pilling them out in rows with the roots facing the same direction.
- Peel of one leaf and/or cleans off any old, diseased or damaged leaves
- Trims off the tops by cutting across the leaves at the same height. Do the trimming on the large green boxes and trim the leaves at the same length as the bin.

- Gather all leeks in harvest bins and bring back to the washing station.
- 1 person should harvest at least 60 leeks/hour

CONDITIONING

- Leeks are washed using a pressure gun. Upon arriving from the fields, the bins are transferred to the cart and placed to the left of the sinks.
- A lot of leeks are placed side by side with the roots facing the operator. The operator then sprays the soil off with the gun. Turn the bunches over and repeat. Then pile to the right.
- If bunching leeks put 2-4 leeks per bunch making bunches uniform in size.
- put in storage bin and identify the bin.
- 1 person should package at least 100 bunches per hour.

STORING

- Leeks are stored in cold room kept at 35 °F (2 °C)